time that the famous Chinese pilgrim Hsuan Tsang (or Yuan Chwang) came to India (in 629 **A.C**.). Harshavardhana was a poet and dramatist and he gathered round his court many artists and poets, making his capital Ujjayini, a famous centre of cultural activities. Harsha died in 648 **A.C**., just about the time when Islam was emerging from the deserts of Arabia, to spread out rapidly across Africa and Asia.

South India

In South India for more than 1,000 years after the Maurya Empire had shrunk and finally ceased to be, great states flourished. The Andhras had defeated the Shakas and were later the contemporaries of the Kushans; then came the Chalukyan Empire in the west to be followed by the Rashtrakutas. Further south were the Pallavas who were mainly responsible for the colonizing expeditions from India. Later came the Chola Empire which spread right across the peninsula and conquered Ceylon and Southern Burma. The last great Chola ruler, Rajendra,

died in 1044 **A.C.**

Southern India was especially noted for its fine products and